

Accessibility Policy

Policy Summary & Knowledge Check

Authority	Chief Operating Officer
Date Ratified	December 6, 2024
Next Review Date	December 2027
Previous Amendments	N/A
Related Document(s)	USC AODA Multi Year Plan
Delegate(s)	Senior Manager, People and Development

Policy Summary

This policy reflects the USC's commitment to equal access and participation for people with disabilities and to meeting accessibility requirements under the Accessibility for Ontarians with Disabilities Act (AODA) and Ontario's accessibility laws, alongside its obligations under the Ontario Human Rights Code. It applies to paid USC staff and covers training, assistive devices, communication, service animals, support persons, notice of disruption, feedback, document availability, self-service kiosks, information and communications standards, employment accommodation, and the design of public spaces.

Key Takeaways

- Applies to all paid USC employees, including those compensated through honoraria; "disability" covers a broad range of visible and invisible conditions, including visual, hearing, or speech impairments, mobility disabilities, brain injury, epilepsy, intellectual or learning disabilities, mental health challenges, and reliance on a service animal or mobility device.
- The Senior Manager, People and Development administers the policy (the COO steps in if conflicted); AODA obligations do not substitute for or limit obligations under the Ontario Human Rights Code.
- Staff are trained annually, and whenever policies or procedures change, on accessible customer service, other AODA standards, and relevant aspects of the Ontario Human Rights Code, with training tailored to specific roles and records maintained.
- Assistive devices are welcomed; where a device presents a significant, unavoidable health or safety concern, other measures will be used. Service animals are welcomed on public premises, with documentation from a regulated health professional sometimes required if the animal isn't easily identifiable.
- Support persons are permitted to accompany a person with a disability at no fee or fare; the USC may require a support person for health or safety reasons only after consulting the person, considering available evidence, and confirming there is no other reasonable way to protect health or safety, with any required admission fee waived.
- Temporary service disruptions require prompt public notice covering the reason, length, and alternatives; documents related to accessible customer service are available on request in accessible formats or with communication supports, at no additional cost and in a timely manner.
- The USC will meet WCAG 2.0 Level AA website requirements, and follows detailed employment accommodation obligations from recruitment and hiring through individualized workplace emergency response plans and return-to-work processes for disability-related absences.
- Design of public spaces, such as Concrete Beach and service counters, must meet AODA built-environment requirements under the Integrated Accessibility Standards Regulation, including specific service counter clear-knee-space dimensions.

Knowledge Check

8 situational questions to check understanding of this policy. An answer key follows on the next page.

- Q1.** An applicant is selected to participate in an interview process. What must the USC do regarding accommodations?
- A. Accommodations are only discussed after the applicant's first 90 days of employment.
 - B. Nothing, unless the applicant is ultimately hired.
 - C. Notify the applicant that accommodations are available upon request, and consult with them to provide or arrange suitable accommodation.
 - D. Only offer accommodations after a formal complaint is filed.
- Q2.** A customer's service animal isn't easily identifiable by a harness or vest, and staff need to confirm it's required for a disability. What can staff request?
- A. A government-issued identification card for the animal.
 - B. Proof of veterinary vaccination only.
 - C. Nothing — staff may never ask for confirmation.
 - D. Documentation from a regulated health professional confirming the person needs the service animal for reasons relating to their disability.
- Q3.** The USC is redesigning a service counter in a public space. What minimum clear knee space must it provide from the public-facing side, per this policy?
- A. 750 mm wide x 680 mm high x 250 mm deep, with additional toe space beyond.
 - B. 1000 mm wide x 800 mm high x 300 mm deep.
 - C. No specific dimensions are required.
 - D. 500 mm wide x 500 mm high x 200 mm deep.
- Q4.** An employee with a disability needs individualized workplace emergency information. When will the USC review this information?
- A. Only once, when the employee is first hired.
 - B. When the employee changes location, when their accommodation needs or plans are reviewed, or when the employer reviews its general emergency response policies.
 - C. Only if requested in writing on an annual basis.
 - D. Never — this is handled entirely by the employee.
- Q5.** A person with a disability requests an accessible format of a USC document. What cost, if any, can be charged?
- A. A cost determined case-by-case with no cap.
 - B. A standard administrative fee.
 - C. No additional cost — the format will be provided at no additional cost and in a timely manner.
 - D. A cost equal to printing and shipping expenses.
- Q6.** If an assistive device presents a significant and unavoidable health or safety concern, what does the USC commit to doing?
- A. Requiring a liability waiver with no further accommodation.
 - B. Charging an additional insurance fee.
 - C. Prohibiting the person with a disability from accessing the premises.
 - D. Using other measures to ensure the person with a disability can still access goods, services, or facilities.
- Q7.** Before requiring a support person for health or safety reasons, what must the USC do first?
- A. Consult with the person with a disability, consider available evidence, and determine there is no other reasonable way to protect health or safety.
 - B. Only obtain approval from the Senior Manager, Communications.
 - C. Post a general public notice, with no individual consultation required.
 - D. Nothing — it can require a support person unilaterally.
- Q8.** What accessibility standard must USC websites meet under this policy?

- A.** WCAG 1.0 Level A.
- B.** WCAG 2.0 Level AA.
- C.** WCAG 2.1 Level AAA.
- D.** No specific standard is required.

Answer Key

Q1: C — Section 5.11.1 states the USC notifies job applicants selected for an assessment or selection process that accommodations are available upon request, and consults with and provides or arranges suitable accommodation.

Q2: D — Section 5.4.2 states staff may ask for documentation from a regulated health professional when a service animal cannot be easily identified.

Q3: A — Section 5.12.3.1.a specifies clear knee space of 750 mm wide x 680 mm high x 250 mm deep below the service counter, with additional toe space of 750 mm wide x 230 mm high x 230 mm deep.

Q4: B — Section 5.11.7 lists these three triggers for reviewing individualized workplace emergency response information.

Q5: C — Section 5.8.2 states the USC will provide accessible formats or communication supports at no additional cost and in a timely manner.

Q6: D — Section 5.2.2 states that where an assistive device presents a significant and unavoidable health or safety concern, other measures will be used to ensure access.

Q7: A — Section 5.5.5 requires consultation with the person with a disability, consideration of available evidence, and confirmation that no other reasonable option exists before making this decision.

Q8: B — Section 5.10.5 states the USC will meet internationally-recognized WCAG 2.0 Level AA website requirements.